

Assignment 3: Reflections and Lessons from the Internship

1. Overview of the Internship

This summer, I interned with 1024 Movement, a Bay Area-based mental health nonprofit dedicated to supporting youth ages 10–24 as they navigate anxiety, depression, and suicide-related challenges. I worked approximately 100 hours in a hybrid remote/on-site capacity from July 7 to August 3, 2025. My responsibilities focused heavily on social media strategy and brand development, as well as operational planning for merchandise sales and donor engagement.

Specific tasks included:

- Creating and scheduling Instagram content using Canva and Meta Business Suite, including three recurring series (“Feature Friday”, “Mini Lifeline Book Quote”, and “Tips from the Team”).
- Drafting a refined mission statement to align with 1024’s voice and broaden appeal across secular and faith-based audiences.
- Leading strategy and implementation for a new merchandise storefront, with an emphasis on donation-based pricing and automated fulfillment.
- Writing promotional materials, outreach messages, and posts for both 1024 Movement’s and Christy Pierce Ministries’ social media channels to drive traffic and increase engagement.
- Managing communication with collaborators and overseeing Instagram auto-replies and scheduling systems.
- Assisting in organizational identity development and long-term planning.

The internship allowed me to be highly self-directed, working closely with the founder and gaining insight into both the operational and emotional realities of running a purpose-driven nonprofit.

2. New Things Learned

This internship gave me hands-on exposure to areas I hadn’t deeply explored in previous roles:

- Nonprofit Communication Strategy

I learned how to adapt messaging for different audiences, for example, teens, donors, parents, and peers, while maintaining consistency in tone and mission. Writing content

that is both faith-anchored and inclusive taught me how to navigate brand nuance in sensitive sectors.

- Automated Tools and Back-End Platforms

I became proficient in tools like Meta Business Suite, Canva's Brand Hub, and donation-integrated platforms like Bonfire and Shopify. I also explored alternatives like Amazon Merch to evaluate feasibility for passive fulfillment models.

- Merchandise & Donation Integration

I researched and proposed systems that would allow users to purchase items while optionally donating above cost, balancing branding, fulfillment logistics, and tax-deductibility compliance. This deepened my understanding of how nonprofits intersect with retail tools.

- Mission-Centric Marketing

Rather than sell a product, I had to craft messaging that inspired connection, care, and community. This taught me how to think emotionally and strategically at once.

3. Surprising Observations

Several things stood out as unexpectedly insightful:

- Engagement Doesn't Always Equal Value

Some posts that felt most meaningful internally didn't perform as well online, while simple, visually engaging posts drew more interaction. This reminded me that impact often happens off the screen and helped me redefine my idea of "success" in nonprofit marketing.

- Informality Builds Trust

Casual language, vulnerability, and faith-adjacent messaging often resonated more than polished graphics. This was a shift from the corporate tone I was used to, and it challenged me to lean into authenticity over perfection.

- The Emotional Toll of Mission-Driven Work

Sitting in on discussions about mental health crises and suicide prevention showed me the emotional labor nonprofit leaders often carry. It gave me a deep respect for the heart behind 1024's work, and helped me reflect on boundaries, burnout, and support systems.

4. Positioning Myself for Future Job Interviews

This internship helped me strengthen both hard and soft skills I can confidently highlight in future interviews:

- **Social Media Strategy**

I can now speak to creating and executing a content calendar, writing for multi-audience impact, managing engagement analytics, and increasing follower conversion through targeted posts.

- **Brand Management**

I led efforts to streamline and differentiate 1024's brand from its founder's, creating separate narratives while maintaining thematic unity. This is a skill especially relevant for early-stage startups or nonprofits.

- **Initiative and Independence**

Much of my work was self-managed. I identified needs, created systems, and ran with proposals. I'll be able to demonstrate how I work without constant supervision, a valuable trait for small teams or dynamic environments.

- **Emotional Intelligence and Empathy**

Working on a mental health nonprofit made me more sensitive to tone, timing, and emotional context, especially when communicating online. These are critical skills for any consumer-facing role.

5. EMPAC Model Insights

The EMPAC model (Entertainment, Matching, Price, Assortment, Convenience) primarily applies to retail firms, but many insights carried over into my work with 1024 Movement, especially in the context of selling merchandise and engaging users online.

- **Entertainment**

Our social media content had to be engaging and emotionally resonant. Posts that used humor, storytelling, or powerful visuals performed better. For example, the "Tips from the Team" series features casual, heartfelt advice from real people, making it feel less like a campaign and more like a community.

- **Matching**

We tailored our content to match different audience needs, for example, parents, donors, students, and seekers, by adjusting tone and content themes. We also adjusted design aesthetics to reflect the calm and hopeful atmosphere we wanted associated with the brand.

- Price

The merchandise proposal I developed emphasized donation-based pricing, giving buyers the freedom to pay above base cost. This is different from traditional retail but fits the nonprofit model, offering flexibility while still communicating value.

- Assortment

I proposed offering a tight assortment of items (shirts, mugs, stickers) that fit the brand and minimized logistical complexity. The goal was to build cohesion, not variety for variety's sake.

- Convenience

A major goal was setting up a storefront that required zero oversight. I evaluated fulfillment platforms that could handle orders, shipping, and customer service autonomously, making it easy for supporters to buy and for staff to focus on mission, not logistics.